Vedic people made liberal use of pictograms. A careful study of these pictograms and statues reveals something amazing: many of the religious symbols and ceremonies of the Vedic culture almost perfectly match those of today's Hindus.

Clues from the Sarasvati archeological sites reveal a culture whose priests wore dots on their foreheads, whose married women painted the part in their hair red, and whose religious practitioners folded their legs together in what yogis call "lotus" position while praying. Images chiseled out of clay and stone thousands of years ago show a meditating man who bears a strong resemblance to the Hindu's Lord Shiva. The similarities are incredible, and they serve to strengthen the ties between modern and ancient India and denote an indigenous culture of all the lands in which the Sarasvati once lived.

The Vedic religion is believed to have begun shifting into a structure that more closely represents Hinduism by the 5th century BCE, though the Vedas remain the central focus of Hinduism today. The people who first read and spoke of them do not much resemble those who chant the Rig-Veda now; however, the former was a largely pastoral people whose livelihoods depended on raising animals for meat and milk.

Until about 1500 BCE, those who believed in the story of sleeping Lord Vishnu and the lotus universe lived in small urban communities that were linked to one another mostly via the waterways of the Land of Seven Rivers. Sarasvati homes and temples featured a fire pit, around which people would gather and worship Indra as a fire god. Priests and many Hindu followers continue this practice today, chanting thousands of hymns together that were passed down orally for millennia. The modern version of that Vedic fire god is Agni, who represents the sun, the hearth fire, lightning, and the flames of sacred sacrificial offerings.

The true difference between Hinduism and the Vedic religion of ancient India is complex, but one might say that the first urges its followers to search for truth, and the second urges them to honor the traditions of the past. That initial curiosity for meaning and truth is perhaps embodied best by the following Vedic poem, which questions even its own story of creation:

> Who really knows, and who can swear,
> How creation came, when or where!